INDIA TODAY CONCLAVE MUMBAI

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After a two-year hiatus necessitated by the Covid-19 pandemic, the INDIA TODAY Conclave Mumbai returned to the Maximum City with two days full of insights, entertainment and debates. From politics, law and society to business and films, the platform brought together personalities from a range of areas, who spoke about the most crucial issues facing India at present.

Day one began with a discussion on the political climate of the host state, with Maharashtra chief minister Eknath Shinde making an emphatic assertion—that his faction is the true custodian of the legacy of the late Shiv Sena founder, Balasaheb Thackeray. This was followed by conversations on the future of what's now a divided, broken party, and the insights of Thackeray's grandson, Aaditya, were illuminating. Also in focus was the legacy of the widely revered Maratha ruler Chhatrapati Shivaji, with author Vaibhav Purandare emphasising how the warrior king stood for "religious plurality".

Women politicians spoke about the prejudices they face, and Shiv Sena leader Priyanka Chaturvedi said more women in Parliament would mean a "more fun, equitable, inclusive space". Day one ended with law minister Kiren Rijiju reiterating the need to reform the collegium system, and transport minister Nitin Gadkari proclaiming that by the next Lok Sabha elections, road accidents will be down by 50 per cent.

With Mumbai being home to Bollywood, the conclave was also a glitzy, star-studded affair. While actors like Abhishek Bachchan, Radhika Apte and Rajkummar Rao talked about how online streaming has changed the entertainment industry for the better, actor Yash recounted his journey from Karnataka to becoming a pan-India star after *KGF*. Actress Bhumi Pednekar put her acting hat aside to talk about climate change, and Varun Dhawan made headlines for admitting that Bollywood films have been struggling of late. Meanwhile, cricketer Shikhar Dhawan showed off his slick dance moves.

The conclave also saw broad discussions on the state of the economy and for many, high inflation remained a key concern. Other hot topics included misconceptions around hemp, and 'moonlighting' becoming a post-pandemic reality.

Author Devdutt Pattanaik made a compelling argument for pluralism, while American sociologist Salvatore Babones became the new favourite of the right after he said that "India's intellectual class is anti-India". Other prominent personalities who attended the conclave included Groupon CEO-turned-YouTuber Ankur Warikoo, and monk, author and lifestyle strategist Swami Gaur Gopal Das, who shared tips on achieving happiness and success. ■

Suhani Singh



Photographs by **BANDEEP SINGH**

▲ NEWSMAKER

"We are educating people [about road accidents], bringing changes to the law. But we need the people and media to cooperate"

NITIN GADKARI
Union Minister for
Road Transport & Highways

▶ KEYNOTE

" What I did is not a rebellion, it was a revolt. I didn't go to the Bharatiya Janata Party to become the chief minister. I did this for ideology and for what Balasaheb always stood for"

EKNATH SHINDE
Chief Minister, Maharashtra

